

with complex international gangs plying their mechanisms in intricately devious ways. And phishing is one of the highly successful cybercrimes, prompting banks to create awareness and cybercrime units to carry out intensive investigations.

While customers get wary of internet banking, phishing attacks are becoming more complex and highly ingenious. While earlier phishing attempts require users to visit the website, the more modern ones have an embedded link in the mail. Accidental clicking on these can lead to disastrous results – the download of a Trojan virus monitoring the user's surfing activity, giving easy access to cybercriminals. Some attacks may be put together sloppily and come across as fraudulent but others are highly sophisticated. Worse, this is conducted invisibly and users don't realise the risk they run until too late. However, there are ways to stay safe from phishing.

Avoid websites which are suspicious and be careful with emails from any company requesting for personal or financial information. On a similar vein, don't ever click a link in a mail, even if you have the mildest suspicion of the sites authenticity.

Similarly, type out the URL of your bank rather than clicking links. And before you start, check if the website you are visit is secure. Easy way to do this is by looking out for the padlock sign on the browser's toolbar. This means that the site which you are visiting is secure.

Change with the times

Never open attachments in your mail, unless you are sure of the sender very well.

Before logging in, check if your browser is updated, especially with relevant security patches. For Internet Explorer browsers, there is a special plug in to block out certain phishing attempts. Other browsers like Firefox or Opera are safer than IE.

It also is a good idea to use a personal firewall, equipped with anti-phishing toolbars that can immediately inform you if a phishing site comes along. Similar software can also be used to remove spyware.

Many users have the habit of storing information of their account on files in the system. This can be dangerous. But more importantly, be aware of internet fraud and also cultivate judiciousness to fake emails.

Read up on phishing and arm yourself with the latest updates. For instance, a lot of phishing attempts emerge as a plea for donations, espe-